

The Necromancer

Game Overview (2-Pager, Beta v1.1)

Version: Beta v1.1

Date: 2026-02-14

1. What This Game Is

The Necromancer is a tactical, turn-based, permadeath roguelike set in Dol Guldur in the Third Age.

You are not clearing a sandbox. You are executing a mission under pressure: - descend, - recover **Thrain's map and key**, - return to floor 1, - escape before the run collapses.

The game is inspired by Sil-Q's design discipline: positional combat, meaningful scarcity, and Tolkien-anchored tone.

2. Why It Exists

Classic roguelikes proved that mechanics can carry narrative weight through consequences. Sil-Q proved how elegant and severe that can be in Tolkien's First Age. The Necromancer extends that ethos into the Third Age and ports it into Godot for broader accessibility, cleaner presentation, and modern onboarding while preserving core principles.

3. Core Gameplay Pillars

1. **Lethal Tactical Combat** Position and sequencing matter more than raw aggression.
2. **Stealth and Information Play** Choosing engagements is often stronger than winning every engagement.

3. **Scarce Resource Economies** Light and voice are strategic currencies, not passive bars.
4. **Permadeath Mastery Loop** Loss teaches. Knowledge compounds. Success is earned.

4. Beta v1.1 Highlights

- Escape condition implemented and objective-gated.
- Light economy baseline corrected (including Elvish Light and Jeweled Lamp behavior).
- Voice economy tightening to reduce sustain abuse.
- Utility/hotbar reliability improvements for activatable items.
- Action economy fix direction: non-attack setup actions should generally be minor actions.
- Documentation refresh for internal testing and onboarding.

5. How a Run Works

1. Create character (race, house, trait, stats).
2. Stabilize early floors (weapon, survivability, light).
3. Spend XP to solve current failure mode.
4. Descend and recover Thrain objective.
5. Ascend under threat pressure.
6. Escape or die.

6. Who Will Enjoy It

Players who like: - high-stakes tactical decisions, - meaningful failure, - Tolkien-literate atmosphere, - mechanical depth over power fantasy padding.

Players who may not: - low-friction progression seekers, - players wanting reversible mistakes or safe grinding.

7. Current Beta Win Condition

You can complete Beta v1.1 by: 1. obtaining **Thrain's map and key**, 2. reaching the upstairs on floor 1, 3. triggering the beta ending message and return to menu.

8. What Comes Next

Post-beta priorities: - full exterior post-escape chapter, - deeper balancing across light/voice and late-depth pressure, - expanded narrative payoff and end states.

For practical play instructions, see: - docs/manual/
THE_NECROMANCER_PLAYERS_GUIDE_BETA_V1_1.md - tutorial.md